COORDINATION AND INCUMBENCY ADVANTAGE IN MULTI-PARTY SYSTEMS—EVIDENCE FROM FRENCH ELECTIONS

Kevin Dano
Princeton University, United States

Francesco Ferlenga
University of Warwick, United Kingdom

Vincenzo Galasso
Bocconi University, Italy

Caroline Le Pennec
HEC Montréal, Canada

Vincent Pons
Harvard Business School, United States

Abstract
Free and fair elections should incentivize elected officials to exert effort and enable citizens to select representative politicians and occasionally replace incumbents. However, incumbency advantage and coordination failures possible in multi-party systems may jeopardize this process. We ask whether these two forces compound each other. Using a regression discontinuity design (RDD) in French two-round local and parliamentary elections, we find that close winners are more likely to run again and to win the next election by 33 and 25 percentage points, respectively. Incumbents who run again personalize their campaign communication more and face fewer ideologically close competitors, revealing that parties from the incumbent's orientation coordinate more effectively than parties on the losing side. A complementary RDD shows that candidates who marginally qualify for the runoff also rally new voters. We conclude that party coordination on the incumbent and voter coordination on candidates who won or gained visibility in a previous election both contribute to incumbents' future success. (JEL: D72, K16, P00)

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E-mail: kdano@princeton.edu (Dano); francesco.ferlenga@warwick.ac.uk (Ferlenga); vincenzo.galasso@unibocconi.it (Galasso); caroline.le-pennec@hec.ca (Le Pennec); vpons@hbs.edu (Pons)

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1. Introduction

In theory, free and fair elections can improve the selection of politicians and decrease moral hazard: Citizens can use elections to choose leaders who are competent and aligned with their preferences (Downs 1957; Osborne and Slivinski 1996; Besley and Coate 1997; Fearon 1999), and the prospect of facing reelection gives politicians incentives to exert effort (Barro 1973; Ferejohn 1986; Besley 2006). In practice, bad incumbents may manage to get reelected and reelection incentives may be weakened if holding power gives a systematic advantage over competitors. A large literature has documented the existence of an incumbency advantage in the United States and in other countries using first-past-the-post elections, where individual races tend to be dominated by only two or a handful of parties (e.g., Lee 2008). Incumbents can provide pork barrel spending, and they often obtain more media coverage and larger electoral campaign funding. These advantages may scare off high-quality challengers and jeopardize the process of democratic alternation and elite renewal. We refer to these mechanisms existing in two-party systems as "direct" contributors to the incumbency advantage.

In multi-party settings, in which a large number of candidates compete for any seat, a second, more indirect, force can contribute to the victory of bad politicians: coordination failures. Parties from the same orientation (e.g., parties on the left) have incentives to reach candidate dropout agreements, in order to reduce the number of ideologically close competitors and increase their chances of winning. Furthermore, voters may strategically rally behind stronger candidates. However, the coordination efforts of parties and voters may fail (e.g., Pons and Tricaud 2018).

In this paper, we ask whether the mechanisms directly giving incumbents an advantage and coordination issues compound each other. Coordination issues might reinforce direct mechanisms of incumbency advantage if incumbents seeking reelection are better able to prevent ideologically close candidates from entering the race or to rally their base voters. Conversely, parties defeated in the previous election may decide to join forces to avoid a new defeat and voters from the losing political orientation may coordinate on the most promising candidate. Moreover, new candidates may enter on the incumbent's side if they expect this side to win again. If parties and voters on the losing side are better able to coordinate, the resulting, total incumbency advantage may be lower or even disappear, facilitating elite renewal.

To assess the interaction between coordination failures and direct mechanisms of incumbency advantage, we use a regression discontinuity design (RDD) in a multi-party environment, the French local and parliamentary elections. We measure the effects of close electoral victories on the probability of winning and on the composition of the candidate pool in the next election. The elections we study use a two-round plurality voting rule and they often feature a large number of candidates in the first round, making coordination issues particularly important.[1] Elected officials face no term limits, making any systematic incumbency advantage particularly consequential. Our sample includes a total of more than 20,000 races, which enables us to explore

1. Coordination issues may also be present and favor incumbents in countries with single-round first-past-the-post elections, as long as they sustain a multi-party system.

the mechanisms underlying the effects on our main outcomes through heterogeneity analyses, while maintaining sufficient statistical precision.

We first document the existence of a large incumbency advantage in French multiparty elections: The victory of a candidate increases their likelihood of winning the next election by 25.1 percentage points (pp). We also identify each candidate's party and political orientation (from far-left to far-right) and measure incumbents' advantage at these two additional levels as well, to account for the possibility that parties on the losing side replace their candidate more often. The party-level and orientation-level incumbency advantage indicate how a candidate's close victory affects their party and orientation's likelihood of winning the next election. The effect of winning the present election on winning the next one is lower but remains substantial at the party and orientation levels: 13.3 and 12.3 pp, respectively. Moreover, the incumbency advantage is sizable for candidates of different orientations, and in both local and parliamentary elections.

Second, we estimate the effects of a close victory on the likelihood that the candidate or other candidates of their party participate in the next election, which may directly contribute to the effect on winning. Incumbents are more likely by 32.9 pp than their closest challenger to compete again in the next election. The impact is also positive at the party level, but smaller and non-significant.

Third, we estimate the effects of a close victory on the likelihood that other candidates from the same orientation of the incumbent participate in the next election. A close victory decreases the number of competitors from the candidate's orientation by 0.43 on average, which corresponds to a 23% decrease compared to the mean at the left of the threshold. The effect on the total number of candidates from the same orientation (including the candidate themselves when they run again) is also negative, although it falls short of statistical significance. Interestingly, the drop in the number of competitors is driven by competitors belonging to political parties more than by independent candidates from the same orientation, suggesting that the lower number of ideologically close competitors faced by the incumbent primarily results from dropout agreements between parties. We conclude that party coordination is more effective on the side of the incumbent. Thus, better coordination reinforces the direct mechanisms giving incumbents an advantage, which have been identified in previous work on two-party systems.

Fourth, using a bounding strategy, we show that incumbents obtain a larger vote share (by 3.0–19.8 pp) and are more likely to win (by 8.0–33.9 pp) than their closest challenger, conditional on running again. We also find that incumbents who run again face fewer ideologically close competitors than challengers who run again, which may partly drive the effect on winning. However, beyond candidate and party decisions to compete, incumbency advantage may also be driven by voters rallying the incumbent in the next election. In fact, incumbents may receive more contributions or run better campaigns. We explore these possibilities by measuring effects on campaign expenditures and on the content of two-page candidate manifestos mailed by the state to all registered voters. While incumbents do not raise significantly more money than their closest challenger in the previous election, conditional on running again, we find that their manifestos are more original, where manifesto originality is defined relatively to other candidates from the same party. This suggests that incumbents' communication strategy is more personalized and better-tailored to their voters' preferences. Incumbents may also represent a focal point for voters in the subsequent election. To provide evidence on this mechanism, we use a separate regression discontinuity design and estimate the impact of qualifying for the runoff on the next election's results. Unlike winning the election (and becoming the incumbent), qualifying for the runoff does not generate the advantages coming from holding office, and we show that it does not affect the number of competitors from the same orientation in the next election. However, it does increase candidates' future vote share, conditional on running again. This suggests that candidates who do well in an election, even without being elected to office, become focal points for voters. Similarly, voters are likely to coordinate on the winner of the past election, contributing to the incumbency advantage that we document.

Literature Review

We build on a vast literature documenting the existence of an electoral advantage for incumbent politicians seeking reelection. Evidence of an incumbency advantage in the United States dates back to Erikson (1971). Since Lee (2008), researchers have used regression discontinuity designs to provide rigorous causal evidence on this phenomenon, both at the candidate and the party level (Fowler and Hall 2014). In the United States, they have found consistent evidence of an incumbency advantage in state (Uppal 2010), city council (Krebs 1998; Trounstine 2011), federal (Butler 2009), and primary elections (Ansolabehere et al. 2007; Olson 2020). A large incumbency advantage also exists in other countries using first-past-the-post elections, including the United Kingdom (Katz and King 1999; Eggers and Spirling 2017), Australia (Horiuchi and Leigh 2009), and Canada (Kendall and Rekkas 2012). Matland and Studlar (2004) suggest that the incumbency advantage is lower in proportional elections, since the presence of multiple incumbents in the same district dilutes the effect. Positive effects have been found in proportional elections in Denmark (Dahlgaard 2016), Finland (Kotakorpi, Poutvaara, and Terviö 2017), France (Gougou 2023), Germany (Hainmueller and Kern 2008; Ade, Freier, and Odendahl 2014), Ireland (Redmond and Regan 2015), Norway (Fiva and Røhr 2018), Portugal (Lopes da Fonseca 2017), Sweden (Liang 2013), but not in Italy (Golden and Picci 2015) and Japan (Ariga 2015), where, if anything, incumbents tend to be disadvantaged.[2]

The incumbency advantage may first arise because incumbent politicians get an edge from holding office (Fiorina 1989; Krebs 1998). Incumbents can engage in clientelism (Nunez 2018; Frey 2019) and pork barrel spending (Fowler and Hall 2015; Spáč 2020). They tend to get disproportional media coverage (Prior 2006;

2. In non-Western countries, the incumbency effect has also often been found to be negative: see Duraisamy, Lemennicier, and Khouri (2014) and Karnik, Lalvani, and Phatak (2023) for India, Roh (2017) for South Korea, and De Magalhaes (2015) and Klašnja and Titiunik (2017) for Brazil.

Schaffner 2006), and may be able to outspend challengers (Fouirnaies and Hall 2014; Holbrook and Weinschenk 2014). Second, the incumbency advantage may arise from systematic differences in the quality of incumbents and challengers. Incumbents may deter high-quality challengers from competing against them (Levitt and Wolfram 1997; Ashworth and Bueno de Mesquita 2008; Hall and Snyder Ban 2015; Llaudet, and Snyder 2016). Differences in quality may also emerge if candidates who marginally lost the election are replaced more often in the next election than incumbents who marginally won and the pool of candidates to choose from is of lower quality than those who made it to a close election (Eggers 2017).

We complement this literature by estimating the size of the incumbency advantage in two-round elections and by documenting a new class of mechanisms: more effective party and voter coordination on the winning side than on the losing side. This mechanism is specific to multi-party systems, which are likely to emerge under voting rules such as two-round plurality voting. Furthermore, the fact that two-round elections allow some non-winners to also gain visibility, by qualifying for the runoff, enables us to isolate the role of voter coordination on focal-point candidates from the effect of holding office.

Our analyses build on recent studies investigating how candidates and voters solve coordination issues when the number of potential candidates is larger than two and, therefore, multiple equilibria exist (Duverger 1954; Palfrey 1989; Myerson and Weber 1993; Cox 1997).[3] Anagol and Fujiwara (2016) show that voters tend to coordinate on candidates who finished a close second rather than third in the previous election, and Granzier, Pons, and Tricaud (2023a) find coordination by both parties and voters on candidates' first-round rankings in two-round elections. However, coordination often remains imperfect. Parties often fail to reach dropout agreements and many voters' choices are driven by expressive motives or by the desire to be on the winning side rather than by strategic considerations (Pons and Tricaud 2018; Granzier, Pons, and Tricaud 2023a). Negative feedback may also undermine strategic coordination since one's incentive to be strategic drops as strategic voting by others increases (Myatt 2007). Pons and Tricaud (2018) show that imperfect coordination can lead to ideologically close candidates splitting the votes of their base and to suboptimal outcomes such as the defeat of the Condorcet winner. In this paper, we investigate how coordination issues interact with incumbency advantage by exploring whether these issues are more severe on the winning or the losing side. We show that parties and voters use electoral history to identify which candidates to coordinate on and that coordination is more effective on the winning side, consistent with predictions by Reed (1990), Forsythe et al. (1993), and Cox (1997).

Finally, our results also contribute to the broader literature studying the properties of two-round plurality rule elections (Bouton 2013; Bordignon, Nannicini, and

3. While Duverger (1954) argues that incentives for voters to behave strategically are weak in the first round of runoff elections, because similar parties can regroup for the runoff, Cox (1997) points that these incentives remain present. Consistent with this view, we show in Section 5.3 that candidates who do well in the current election become focal points for strategic voters in the first round of the next election.

Tabellini 2016; Cipullo 2021; Bouton et al. 2022), a voting system used to elect members of parliament or local governments in many countries, including France, the Czech Republic (Senate), Italy (municipalities), Vietnam, Mali, Uzbekistan, and to elect the head of state in nearly 90 countries.

2. Institutional Setting and Data

2.1. Setting

Our sample includes both parliamentary and local elections.[4]

2.1.1. Parliamentary Elections. The National Assembly is the lower house of the French parliament. In addition to holding the legislative power, it controls the government and can overthrow it. It is currently composed of 577 representatives elected through two-round plurality elections in single-member districts. To be elected in the first round, a candidate needs to obtain the absolute majority of the votes cast in their district, and these votes need to account for at least one quarter of all registered voters. If no candidate wins in the first round, the two candidates who received the most votes in the first round and any other candidate who obtained the votes of at least 12.5% of the registered voters qualify for the second round. The runoff takes place among all qualified candidates who choose to stay in the race instead of dropping out. The candidate who receives a plurality of votes gets elected.

This two-round plurality system has been in place since 1958. The number of representatives has increased slightly over time, and the first round vote share required to qualify for the second round changed from 5% of the expressed votes in 1958 to 10% of the registered voters in 1966 and to the current threshold of 12.5% of the registered voters in 1975.

2.1.2. Local Elections. France is divided into 101 départements, which have responsibilities over education, transportation, and social assistance, among other matters. In each département, a departmental council holds the legislative power and elects a president, who holds the executive power. Members of the departmental council are chosen by small constituencies, the cantons. During our sample period, each canton elected one council member for a six-year mandate. Every three years, half of the cantons voted to renew their representatives.[5]

4. We do not include municipal elections, which use a different voting rule and a list format, instead of single-member constituencies.

5. Since the 2015 election, local elections take place every 6 years in the entire country and they elect tickets composed of a male and a female candidate. Cantons were all redistricted ahead of the 2015 election; hence, this election is excluded from our analysis.

Local elections use a two-round plurality voting rule, similarly as the parliamentary elections. The threshold to qualify for the second round was 10% of the registered voters until 2010, when it was raised to 12.5%.

2.1.3. Party System. Over the sample period, French politics have been dominated by the following seven main parties, ordered from left to right on the ideological scale: Front de Gauche (FDG), Verts (VEC), Parti Socialiste (SOC), Parti radical de gauche (RadGauche), Mouvement Démocrate (MODEM), Union pour un Mouvement Populaire (UMP), and Front National (FN).[6] These parties were long organized into two coalitions (Bornschier and Lachat 2009). The left coalition was dominated by SOC and the right coalition by UMP. These two parties have generally obtained the most votes and seats and they have therefore been the cornerstones of coalitions also involving the MODEM, on the right, and FDG, VEC, and RadGauche, on the left. Electoral alliances can lead to dropout agreements (where one party agrees not to field any candidate) before the first round and between the first and second rounds, as well as endorsement of other parties' candidates. After the election, allied parties often build coalitions at the National Assembly and in departmental councils, and they govern together. FN, on the far-right, has not participated in alliances with parties on the left or on the right, except for a few local elections.

Beyond the seven main parties, elections often feature candidates affiliated with smaller issue-specific parties. Candidates may also run as independents, without the endorsement of any national party. Independent candidates account for 30% of all candidates in our sample and for 19% of the top two contenders in the final round of elections.

2.2. Electoral Data

We use data for all parliamentary elections between 1958 and 2017, except for the 1986 elections, which used a proportional system. We also use data for all local elections between 1979 and 2011. Electoral results were obtained from Granzier, Pons, and Tricaud (2023a).[7] For each electoral district and election year, we have data on the number of candidates, the number of registered voters and expressed votes, and the vote shares obtained by each candidate in both electoral rounds as well as their political label. Our analysis requires linking races over time, from one election to the next. Therefore, we restrict the sample to districts that were not affected by redistricting and whose borders remained identical between two consecutive elections. Our main sample includes observations from 12 parliamentary elections and 10 local elections.[8]

6. We provide more information on each party in Online Appendix D.2.

7. They are made publicly available by the French Ministry of the Interior for elections held after 1988, and they were digitized by Granzier, Pons, and Tricaud (2023b) for elections prior to 1988.

8. Specifically, we focus on parliamentary elections in 1958, 1962, 1967, 1968, 1973, 1978, 1988, 1993, 1997, 2002, 2007, and 2012, and local elections in 1979, 1982, 1985, 1988, 1992, 1994, 1998, 2001,

In each district, we match candidates, parties, and orientations across elections. First, we use fuzzy string matching on candidate names to identify candidates present both in election t and election $t + 1$, and we link candidates at t to their electoral outcomes at $t + 1$. Second, we use the political labels attributed to candidates by the Ministry of the Interior to identify candidates affiliated with one of the seven main parties.[9] We track parties' election-specific names and their genealogy over time-based primarily on Knapp (2004). In each district, we aggregate candidate outcomes at the party level and link candidates at t to their party-level outcomes at $t + 1$.[10] Third, we allocate candidates to six political orientations (far-left, left, center, right, far-right, and non-classified). This is an important classification, since candidates who are not affiliated with any of the seven main parties might nonetheless have a clear political orientation, indicated by labels such as "diverse left" or "diverse right." We thus aggregate candidate outcomes at the orientation level, and link candidates at t to their orientation-level outcomes at $t + 1$.[11]

2.3. *Complementary Data*

2.3.1. Campaign Expenditures. We complement our dataset with the total amount of contributions received by each candidate (from individual donations, party contributions, or personal contributions) and their total expenditures, for all elections since 1992. These data come from the French National Commission on Campaign Accounts and Political Financing. They were collected and digitized by Fauvelle-Aymar and François (2005), Foucault and François (2005), and Granzier, Pons, and Tricaud (2023a).

2.3.2. Candidate Manifestos. In France, individual candidates may issue a two-page electoral manifesto (*"profession de foi"*), distinct from their party's manifesto. The state mails the manifestos of all candidates in a given district to all registered voters of this district a few days before the election. We provide additional details on these

2004, and 2008. Observations from the 2017 parliamentary election and the 2011 local election, which are the last available elections, are only used to construct next-election outcomes for, respectively, the 2012 parliamentary election and either the 2004 or the 2008 local election, depending on the cantons. Furthermore, we do not link districts in 1988 to a previous election or districts in 1981 to a future election, since the 1986 election, which took place in between, followed a different (proportional) electoral rule. Observations from 1981 are still linked to the 1978 election and used to construct next-election outcomes for that year. Online Appendix Tables D.1 and D.2 list all elections in the sample and the elections they are matched with to construct next-election outcomes.

9. The political labels are based on candidates' self-reported political affiliation, party endorsement, past candidacies, and public declarations, among other indicators.

10. In the vast majority of races in our sample, there is only one candidate per party. Only 2% of the top-two contenders in the final round of a race are linked to several candidates from the same party at t+1.

11. For more details on the mapping between candidate labels on one hand and parties and orientations on the other hand, see Online Appendix D.2. The mapping with orientations builds on Granzier, Pons, and Tricaud (2023a). The key outcomes at the candidate, party, and orientation levels are defined in Online Appendix D.6.

documents in Online Appendix D.4 and show an example in Online Appendix Figure D.1.

Our campaign manifesto data cover all parliamentary elections from 1962 to 1997 and the 2017 parliamentary elections. Candidate manifestos were collected and digitized by the CEVIPOF's Archelec project (Gaultier-Voituriez 2016) and Le Pennec (2024) for the 1962– 1993 elections and by Cagé, Le Pennec, and Mougin (2024) for the 1997 election. The 2017 election manifestos were made available online by the Ministry of the Interior and scraped by Regards Citoyens (https://www.regardscitoyens.org/). We obtained them from Le Pennec (2024).

We use an unsupervised approach to construct a measure of manifesto originality with respect to manifestos issued by other candidates from the same party, for candidates affiliated with one of the seven parties. Specifically, we calculate each manifesto's average pairwise similarity to all other manifestos issued in the same election year by candidates from the same party, based on the words appearing in their manifestos. The similarity between any two manifestos is computed in six different ways.[12] The six measures of mean similarity to other manifestos from the same party are then standardized by election year. We define an originality index equal to the average of these six standardized measures. This index reflects the politician's effort and ability to write a personalized campaign message, instead of using a template common to other candidates endorsed by the same party.

In addition to the originality index, we measure the share of words in a manifesto that are first person's personal pronouns (e.g., *"je"*) and the share of words that are past participles (e.g., *"fait"* and *"été"*). These outcomes also reflect the personalization of a candidate's campaign communication, as they capture the candidate's propensity to refer to their own actions and past achievements in their manifesto.

3. Empirical Strategy

3.1. Regression Discontinuity Design

We estimate the causal impact of winning on party coordination and subsequent electoral success by exploiting close races.

After excluding races that cannot be linked to a subsequent election due to redistricting as well as races where the winner ran uncontested, our sample for the candidate-level analysis includes a total of 20,755 races: 5,757 races from parliamentary elections and 14,998 races from local elections.[13] Our sample for the party-level analysis further excludes candidates who are not affiliated with any of the seven main party organizations and races in which the top two contenders are from

12. We define similarity as the cosine similarity between vectors of frequencies or weighted frequencies over unigrams (single words) or bigrams (two-word expressions), or using a Latent Semantic Indexing approach as in Bertrand et al. (2021). For more details, see Online Appendix D.5.

13. See Online Appendix Tables D.1 and D.2 for more details.

the same party. It includes 19,434 races. Races in which the top two contenders are from the same party only account for 0.5% of all races. In general, all candidates are from distinct parties. Our orientation-level sample excludes candidates who cannot be classified on the left-right scale and races in which the top-two contenders are from the same orientation. It includes 18,666 races.

Summary statistics for races included in each sample are displayed in Online Appendix Table D.3. First-round turnout is about 68% on average, in all samples, with an average number of six competing candidates. A runoff is held in 71% of races and the winning margin is 21 percentage points on average. Thanks to the large number of races in our data, many of them are close: The vote share difference between the winner and the closest contender is lower than 5 percentage points in 3,686 races in the main sample.

We use two observations per race, corresponding to the winner and the runner-up. We define our running variable MARG based on the difference between the vote shares obtained by these two candidates in the final round of the election (the first round, if the election was won in the first round, and the second round otherwise). It is positive and equal to the difference between the vote shares of the winner and the runner-up, for the winner, and negative and equal to the difference between the vote shares of the runner-up and the winner, for the runner-up. The treatment variable T is a dummy equal to 1 if the candidate won the election ($Marg > 0$) and 0 otherwise ($Marg < 0$).[14] We use a sharp regression discontinuity design and estimate the following equation:

$$Y_{i,t+1} = \alpha + \tau T_{i,t} + \beta f(Marg_{i,t}) + \gamma T_{i,t} \times f(Marg_{i,t}) + \varepsilon_{i,t+1}, \tag{1}$$

where $Y_{i,t+1}$ is the outcome of interest for candidate i (alternatively, for the party or the orientation of candidate i) in election $t+1$. Our baseline specification is non-parametric, following Imbens and Lemieux (2008) and Calonico, Cattaneo, and Titiunik (2014), and we estimate it using the rdrobust Stata package. The specification amounts to estimating two local linear regressions, one to the left and the other to the right of the cutoff.[15] Our coefficient of interest, τ, corresponds to the difference between the intercepts of the two regressions, evaluated at $Marg = 0$. It estimates the causal impact of winning the election t.[16]

We estimate equation (1) for a wide range of outcomes, including whether the candidate runs again, the number of candidates from the same orientation in the next election, whether the candidate wins the next election, and whether their party or

14. There are nine races in our sample in which the top two contenders obtain the exact same number of votes, in which case the older candidate is designated as winner. We exclude these races from the sample.

15. We show the robustness of our main results to fitting local quadratic regressions instead of linear ones in Online Appendix Table C.1.

16. More precisely, fitting equation (1) delivers an estimate of the average causal effect of winning at $Marg = 0$. That is, $\mathbb{E}[Y_{i,t+1}(1) - Y_{i,t+1}(0) | Marg = 0]$ where $(Y_{i,t+1}(1), Y_{i,t+1}(0))$ denotes the pair of potential outcomes underlying $Y_{i,t+1}$ if candidate i wins or looses the election at time t. As shown in Imbens and Lemieux (2008), this estimand is identified if the conditional means or the conditional distributions of the potential outcomes are continuous in the running variable.

orientation wins the next election. The last two outcomes are defined as dummies equal to 1 if any candidate (whether the candidate themselves or another candidate) from the candidate's party (resp. orientation) wins the next election.[17] We use an identical bandwidth for all outcomes, equal to 5 pp, as in Colonnelli, Prem, and Teso (2020). Indeed, the optimal bandwidths selected by the MSERD procedure from Calonico et al. (2019) and by the method from Imbens and Kalyanaraman (2012) yield surprisingly large values in our setting (e.g., the MSERD method yields a bandwidth of 13.7 pp for the probability of winning the next election). These outcome-specific optimal bandwidths also vary widely across the different outcomes. Using a common bandwidth facilitates the comparison of point estimates across outcomes and subsamples and the assessment of the underlying mechanisms. In Online Appendix Figure C.1, we replicate our main results for a wide range of bandwidth values from 1 to 20 pp, including the bandwidths from Calonico et al. (2019) and Imbens and Kalyanaraman (2012). In all specifications, standard errors are clustered at the district level.

3.2. *Identification Assumption*

We provide standard tests to assess the validity of our RDD.

A usual concern is that candidates of a specific type may manage to systematically sort immediately to the right of the victory cutoff. Such manipulation is unlikely, since it would require candidates to be able to predict the outcome of the race with great accuracy, while several unpredictable events, including weather conditions, make electoral outcomes uncertain. To rule out the presence of sorting empirically, we implement the density test from Cattaneo, Jansson, and Ma (2018). In our setting, this test is satisfied by construction at the candidate level since our sample includes the exact same set of races on both sides of the threshold and, in each race, the winning and losing candidates are equally distant from the cutoff. The samples we use for analyses at the party and orientation levels include a few races with only one candidate, due to the exclusion of candidates who do not belong to one of the seven main parties and of candidates who cannot be classified on the left-right scale, respectively, but the tests remain relatively uninformative. We show the results of the density tests in Online Appendix Figure B.1. As expected, the null hypothesis of no sorting at the threshold cannot be rejected at standard levels of significance, for any of our levels of analysis (candidate, party, or orientation).

Next, we conduct a general test of imbalance by checking whether treatment status predicted based on covariates jumps at the threshold, following Anagol and Fujiwara (2016). We consider variables whose distribution at the cutoff is not mechanically symmetric: a set of six dummies indicating the candidate's orientation; the number of other candidates from the candidate's orientation in the current election, at t; a dummy

17. The running and treatment variables are defined at the candidate level for all outcomes, including the candidate's party or orientation victory at the next election.

indicating if the candidate is affiliated with a party or running as independent[18]; a dummy indicating if the candidate is a woman; dummies indicating if the candidate, their party, and their orientation ran in the previous election, at $t-1$; dummies indicating if they, their party, and their orientation won at $t-1$; their first round vote share, the vote share of their party, and that of their orientation at $t-1$ (set equal to 0 if they, their party, and their orientation did not run, respectively); and the number of other candidates from the same orientation at $t-1$.[19] Using our sample of top two contenders as described above, we regress each candidate's actual treatment status T on these variables and generate their predicted treatment assignment based on the regression's coefficients.[20] We then test whether predicted values jump at the victory cutoff.

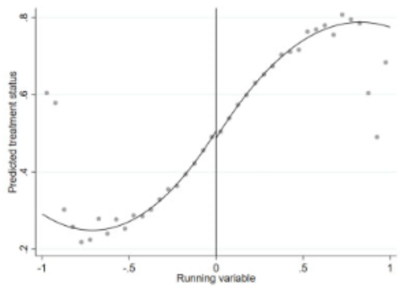
Figure 1 shows the results. Each dot represents the probability of being treated within a given bin of the running variable—that is, the vote share difference between the first two candidates. Winning candidates are located to the right of the threshold, and losing ones to the left. A quadratic fit on each side of the cutoff is provided as a visual assistance. Figure 1(a) does not reveal any discontinuity when using our sample for the candidate-level analysis. Figure 1(b) and (c) does not show any discontinuity in the party-level or the orientation-level sample either. Table 1 shows the corresponding point estimates: coefficients for the three levels of analysis are small and non-significant. As shown in Online Appendix Figure C.2, this is true for a large range of bandwidth values, including those chosen optimally using the MSERD and IK procedures.

We finally test whether there is a discontinuity in any of the individual variables used to predict treatment. Online Appendix Figure B.2 shows that there is no discontinuity in the probability that the candidate (or the candidate's party or orientation) won or ran in election $t-1$, nor in the number of other candidates from the same orientation in the current and in the previous election. Online Appendix Table B.1 shows results for all other variables, in the candidate-level sample. All estimates are small and non-significant, except for the candidate's orientation: columns (1) thorugh (5) of panel a suggest that close winners are more often from the center and the right.

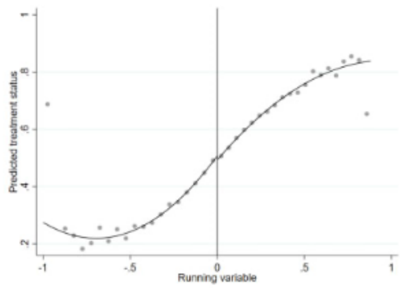
18. Independent candidates are those whose political label assigned by the Ministry of the Interior does not correspond to a party organization. The classification of labels between parties and non-parties was performed by Granzier, Pons, and Tricaud (2023a). Note that candidates affiliated with a party are never considered independent, including if this party is not one of the seven main parties that we focus on.

19. Other variables such as the number of registered voters, the total number of candidates, voter turnout, or the candidate's vote share at the decisive stage are smooth at the threshold, by construction, since they take the same value for the observations corresponding to the incumbent and to the runner-up of a given race, so we do not take them into account in this test.

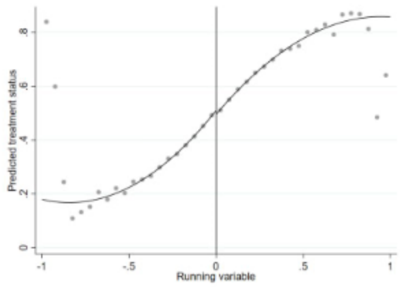
20. Outcomes at t-1 are set to missing in districts that have been redistricted since the previous election, for all observations in the 1988 parliamentary election (which was preceded by an election with a different electoral rule), and for observations in the 1958 parliamentary election and the 1979 local election (which are the earliest elections in our sample). To avoid dropping observations, for each regressor, we include a dummy equal to 1 when the variable is missing and we replace missing values by 0. Each covariate is described in more detail in Online Appendix D.7.



(a) Candidate level



(b) Party level



(c) Orientation level

FIGURE 1. General balance test. Dots represent the local averages of the predicted treatment status (vertical axis). Averages are calculated within equally spaced bins of the running variable (horizontal axis). The running variable (the vote share difference between the first two candidates) is measured as percentage points, and each bin is 5-pp wide. Continuous lines are a quadratic fit. In Figure 1(b), we use our party-level sample. In Figure 1(c), we use our orientation-level sample.

TABLE 1. General balance test.

	Predicted treatment status		
	(1) Candidate	(2) Party	(3) Orientation
Treatment effect	−0.003	0.006	0.001
	(0.011)	(0.012)	(0.012)
Robust p-value	0.787	0.411	0.555
Observations	7,372	5,850	6,575
Polynomial order	1	1	1
Bandwidth	0.050	0.050	0.050
Mean, left of threshold	0.491	0.491	0.493

Notes: Standard errors, shown in parentheses, are clustered at the district level. We compute statistical significance based on the robust p-value and indicate significance at 1%, 5%, and 10% with ***, **, and *, respectively. The unit of observation is the candidate. In column (2), we use our party-level sample. In column (3), we use our orientation-level sample. The outcome is the value of the treatment predicted by candidate-level (column 1), party-level (column 2), and orientation-level (column 3) baseline variables listed in the text. The treatment variable is a dummy equal to 1 if the candidate wins the election. We use local polynomial regressions: We fit separate polynomials of order 1 on each side of the threshold, using a bandwidth of 5 pp. The mean, left of the threshold gives the value of the outcome for the losing candidate at the threshold.

Our main results are virtually identical when controlling for candidate orientation fixed effects, as shown in Online Appendix Table C.2.[21]

4. Main Results

4.1. Impact on the Likelihood of Winning the Next Election

We first test for the existence of an incumbency advantage in French parliamentary and local elections by measuring the impact of a close victory on the odds of winning the following election. We conduct this analysis at the candidate, party, and orientation levels. The outcome is a dummy equal to 1 if the candidate (or the candidate's party or orientation) wins the next election, and 0 if they run and lose or if they do not run. Thus, this outcome is defined whether the candidate (or their party or orientation) is present in the next election or not.[22]

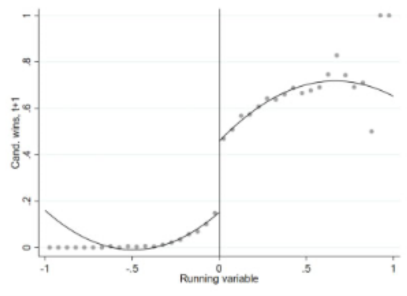
The effects at the candidate, party, and orientation levels are nested within each other. Indeed, unsuccessful candidates may be replaced by another candidate from the same party in the next election. Candidates who were replaced do not have any chance of winning, but their party may win if they run with another candidate. Similarly, a party might be less inclined to run following a defeat, jeopardizing its potential future victory. However, another party or an independent candidate from the same orientation may run, thereby providing the orientation with an opportunity to win. If defeated candidates are more likely to be replaced in the next election, we should expect the incumbency advantage to be larger at the candidate level than at the party and orientation levels.

Figure 2(a) plots the likelihood that the first and second candidates in the current election win the next election against the running variable. We observe a marked discontinuity at the cutoff: Winning the current election dramatically increases a candidate's odds of winning the next one. Figure 2(b) and (c) shows that winning the current election also increases the odds that *any* candidate (either the same candidate or another one) from the same party and the same orientation, respectively, wins the next election.

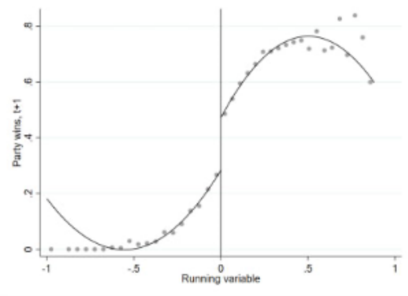
Table 2 complements the graphical analysis with formal estimates of the effects. On average, the victory of a candidate increases their likelihood of winning the next election by 25.1 pp (column 1), an effect that is statistically significant at the 1% level

21. While all these tests provide reassuring evidence that our results are internally valid, we must keep in mind that, by design, our RDD estimates the causal impact of closely winning the election. Therefore, our findings may only apply to competitive races that are won by a small margin, not races won in a landslide. Summary statistics for the sample of races included within the 5-pp bandwidth are provided in Online Appendix Table D.4. These races tend to include more candidates and to take place in larger constituencies than the average race (see Online Appendix Table D.3).

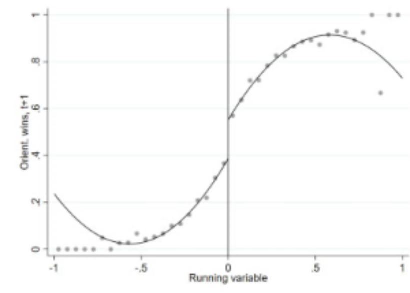
22. We provide more details on the definition of this outcome and all others in Online Appendix D.6.



(a) Candidate wins the next election



(b) Party wins the next election



(c) Orientation wins the next election

FIGURE 2. Impact of winning on winning the next election. Dots represent the local averages of the outcome: A dummy equal to 1 if the candidate (or the candidate's party or orientation) wins the next election (vertical axis). Averages are calculated within equally spaced bins of the running variable (horizontal axis). The running variable (the vote share difference between the first two candidates) is measured as pp, and each bin is 5 pp wide. Continuous lines are a quadratic fit. In Figure 2(b), we use our party-level sample. In Figure 2(c), we use our orientation-level sample.

TABLE 2. Impact of winning on winning the next election.

	Candidate wins, $t+1$ (1)	Party wins, $t+1$ (2)	Orientation wins, $t+1$ (3)
Treatment effect	0.251***	0.133**	0.123**
	(0.023)	(0.027)	(0.026)
Robust p-value	0.000	0.011	0.016
Observations	7,372	5,850	6,575
Polynomial order	1	1	1
Bandwidth	0.050	0.050	0.050
Mean, left of threshold	0.148	0.267	0.366

Notes: Standard errors, shown in parentheses, are clustered at the district level. We compute statistical significance based on the robust p-value and indicate significance at 1%, 5%, and 10% with ***, **, and *, respectively. The unit of observation is the candidate. In column (2), we use our party-level sample. In column (3), we use our orientation-level sample. The outcome is a dummy equal to 1 if the candidate (column 1), the candidate's party (column 2), or the candidate's orientation (column 3) wins the next election. The treatment variable is a dummy equal to 1 if the candidate wins the current election. We use local polynomial regressions: We fit separate polynomials of order 1 on each side of the threshold, using a fixed bandwidth of 5 pp. The mean, left of the threshold gives the value of the outcome for the losing candidate at the threshold.

and represents a 70% increase relative to the average likelihood of winning of close contenders at the left of the threshold. The effect is halved at the party and orientation levels—13.3 and 12.3 pp, respectively (columns 2 and 3)—but the point estimates still represent 50% and 34% increases compared to the average chance of victory of the parties and orientations of losing candidates at the left of the threshold.

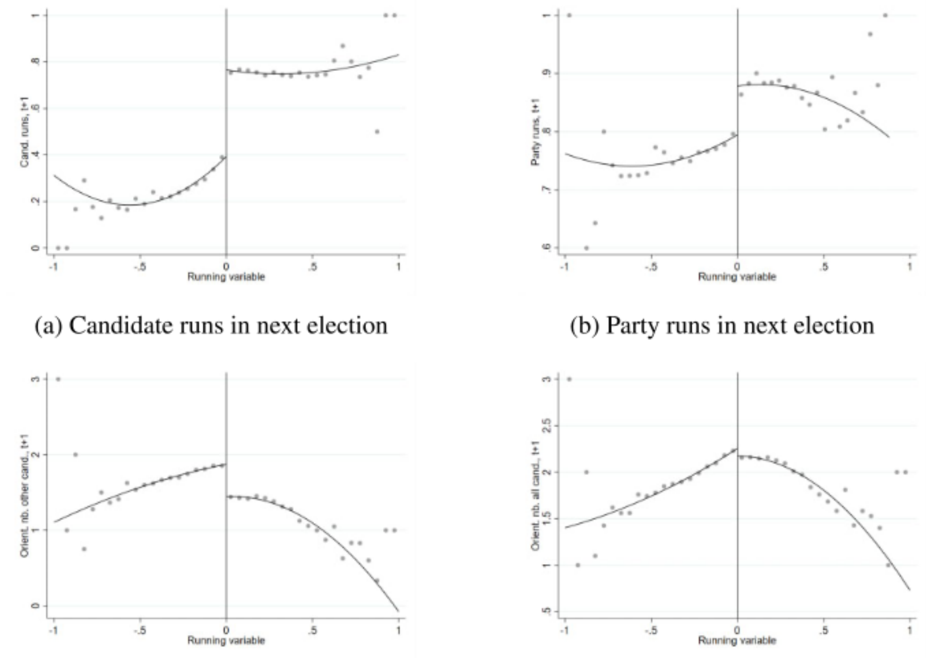
Online Appendix Table C.1 checks the robustness of our results to using bandwidths chosen based on the MSERD procedure from Calonico et al. (2019) and the method from Imbens and Kalyanaraman (2012); tighter and larger bandwidths of 2.5 and 10 pp; and a quadratic specification instead of a linear one. Point estimates at the candidate level are virtually unchanged across all specifications and always remain significant at the 1% level (panel a). Results at the party and orientation levels are also similar across specifications, but point estimates are either non-significant or significant only at the 10% level when using a quadratic specification or a smaller bandwidth (panels b and c, columns 3 and 5). Online Appendix Figure C.1 further shows that our results are robust to a large range of bandwidth values, with smaller and noisier estimates for very narrow bandwidths. Optimal bandwidths are generally larger and yield more precise estimates than our baseline 5-pp bandwidth.

Having established the existence of an incumbency advantage at the individual, party, and orientation levels, we now compare the magnitude of the effect across different settings. Online Appendix Table A.1 shows the heterogeneity results at the candidate level.[23] The treatment effect on the odds of winning the next election is sizable in different types of elections and for candidates of different orientations and party formations. However, the effect is twice as large in local elections as in parliamentary elections (columns 1 and 2), suggesting that the incumbency advantage is stronger in elections, which are less salient or where the identity (valence) of the candidate is more relevant than their party affiliation (ideology). The size of the effect is comparable for men and women (columns 3 and 4), although the point estimate is not significant at conventional levels for female candidates–presumably because very few women get elected over our sample period, resulting in a small sample size. The effect is also comparable for left and far-left candidates, on one hand, and candidates of other orientations, on the other hand (columns 5 and 6). It is slightly larger for candidates running for an opposition party than for candidates belonging to a party of the ruling majority (columns 7 and 8).[24] Finally, the incumbency advantage is slightly larger for candidates of the centrist MODEM party, but it remains sizable and significant for FDG, SOC, and UMP (columns 9–12).[25] Finally, we cut the sample in two halves,

23. Online Appendix Table A.2 shows heterogeneity results using the likelihood of running again as outcome.

24. The ruling majority refers to the party or the coalition of parties that support the ruling national government at the time of the $t+1$ election.

25. The point estimate for the left-wing party FDG falls short of statistical significance due to a smaller sample size (column 9). We exclude the Green party, VEC, and FN from this party-specific analysis as too few of their candidates are close to the threshold.



(a) Candidate runs in next election

(b) Party runs in next election

(c) Number of other candidates from the same orientation in next election

(d) Total number of candidates from the same orientation in next election

FIGURE 3. Impact of winning on candidate entry in the next election. In Figure 3(b), we use our party-level sample. In Figure 3(c) and (d), we use our orientation-level sample. Other notes as in Figure 2.

and we find comparable effects before and after 1994 (columns 13 and 14). Despite significant changes such as the introduction of campaign finance regulations and the emergence of new types of media, the incumbency advantage has remained constant.

The positive effect of winning on winning the next election may stem from impacts on the likelihood that the candidate and their competitors run in the following election, and from an increased probability of winning the election, conditional on rerunning. We build on our RDD framework to disentangle and quantify the importance of each of these two types of channels.

4.2. Impact on Candidate Entry in the Next Election

Figure 3(a) and (b) plots the likelihood of running in the next election against the running variable at the candidate level and at the party level, respectively. In both cases, we observe a large upward jump at the threshold, indicating that the incumbent candidate and party are more likely to run again than the runner-up from the previous election. Additionally, Figure 3(c) and (d) plots the number of candidates from the same orientation running in the next election, respectively excluding and including the

TABLE 3. Impactof winning on candidate entry in the next election.

	Candidate runs, t+1 (1)	Party runs, t+1 (2)	Orientation nb. other candidates, t+1 (3)	Orientation nb. all candidates, t+1 (4)
Treatment effect	0.329***	0.046	−0.426***	−0.129
	(0.024)	(0.021)	(0.066)	(0.062)
Robust p-value	0.000	0.386	0.000	0.166
Observations	7,372	5,850	6,575	6,575
Polynomial order	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	0.050	0.050	0.050	0.050
Mean, left of threshold	0.390	0.796	1.854	2.230

Notes: The outcome is a dummy equal to 1 if the candidate runs (column 1), a dummy equal to 1 if the candidate's party runs (column 2), and the number of other candidates from the same orientation (column 3) or the total number of candidates from the same orientation (column 4) in the next election. In column (2), we use our party-level sample. In columns (3) and (4), we use our orientation-level sample. Other notes as in Table 2.

candidate themselves. One may expect a negative effect on the number of competitors from the same orientation if incumbents become focal points or if they are better able to deter ideologically close challengers from entering the race, as a result of the political power that comes with being in office. Alternatively, a positive effect could emerge if candidates and parties on the losing side decide to join forces in order to reverse the result of the previous election. The quadratic polynomial fit in Figure 3(c) indicates a marked downward jump at the cutoff, in line with the former hypothesis.

In accordance with the graphical evidence, column (1) in Table 3 shows that a candidate's victory increases their odds of running again in the next election by 32.9 pp (84% of the mean at the left of the threshold), which is significant at the 1% level. The impact is also positive, but non-significant, at the party level, with a point estimate of 4.6 pp. The weaker effect at the party level compared to the candidate level supports our explanation for why the unconditional effect of winning at time t on winning at time $t+1$ is more pronounced at the candidate level (Table 2, columns 1 and 2). This is primarily due to defeated candidates being less likely to re-run compared to their defeated party. Finally, a close victory decreases the number of competitors from the candidate's orientation by 0.43 (23%), compared to a close defeat, which is also significant at the 1% level.[26] The effect on the number of candidates from other orientations is mechanically of the exact same magnitude and opposite sign since our RDD compares the number of candidates from the winner's orientation to that of the loser's orientation, while keeping the number of candidates from any other orientation constant. A possible concern with focusing on the number of competitors from the

26. We focus on the number of candidates from the candidate's orientation rather than the candidate's party. Indeed, given that French parliamentary and local elections are held in single-member districts, it is extremely rare for several candidates of the same party to run in the same constituency: Over our sample period, only 6.8% of all races had more than one candidate per party (among our seven main parties). For this reason, we do not discuss issues relevant to multi-member districts on the optimal number of candidates that a party should run, as in Reed (1990) for instance.

same orientation is that, if parties always replace a non-running candidate, this outcome could mechanically jump up to the left of the cutoff, since losing candidates are more likely not to run again. This would thus lead to overestimating the effect. Figure 3(d) and column (4) of Table 3 report the effect on the total number of competitors from the same orientation, including the candidate. In this case, on the contrary, the effect is likely to be underestimated. Since a winning candidate is more likely to re-run, the total number of candidates from the same orientation mechanically increases to the right of the cutoff. It is reassuring that this underestimated coefficient remains negative, even though it falls short of statistical significance. These results are robust to changes in the choice of bandwidth or to using a quadratic specification, as shown in Online Appendix Table C.3. In particular, the effect of winning the current election on the total number of candidates from the same orientation in the next election is negative and significant at the 1% and 5% level, respectively, when using either the MSERD or IK optimal bandwidths (panel d of Online Appendix Table C.3, columns 1 and 2).

In sum, the unconditional impact of winning today on winning again tomorrow is partly driven both by the increased probability that the winner runs again and the lower number of competitors from the same political orientation. The latter effect is concentrated among competitors who are very close ideologically: Winning the current election has a small and non-significant effect on the number of candidates from neighboring orientations (Online Appendix Table A.3). For instance, the victory of a left-wing candidate reduces the number of left-wing competitors in the next election without affecting the number of competitors from the center and the far-left.

We now turn to study whether the effect on re-running suffices to explain the effect on winning or whether winning the present election also increases the likelihood of winning the next one, conditional on running.

4.3. *Impact on the Likelihood of Winning Conditional on Running*

While the RDD ensures that close winners and losers are, on average, similar, there is no guarantee that winners and losers who choose to run again in the next election are similar as well (see, for instance, Eggers 2017). The possibility of differential selection on the two sides of the threshold makes measuring the effects on winning conditional on running more difficult. Suppose, for instance, that all winners run again but only high-quality losers do so. Then, using our RDD on the subsample of candidates present in the next election would likely underestimate the impact of winning conditional on re-running.

We address this selection issue with an approach borrowed from Anagol and Fujiwara (2016) and Granzier, Pons, and Tricaud (2023a), and detailed in Online Appendix E. Intuitively, the overall effect of winning an election on winning the next includes two components. First, candidates who win an election are more likely to run in the next election, as shown in Section 4.2. In and of itself, that increased likelihood of running again will increase their likelihood of winning again. To determine by how much, the effect on running again should be scaled by the unobserved likelihood of winning the next election of candidates who lost the present election and chose not to run in the next one but who would have run again had they won the present election. Second, all candidates who won the present election and run again benefit from an advantage coming from the fact that they won and hold office: The effect of winning on winning again conditional on re-running, which is the effect we want to estimate now. Based on that decomposition, that second component (the effect of winning an election on winning the next one, conditional on re-running) can be written as a function of the following terms. It depends on the effect of winning on re-running as well as the unconditional effect of winning on winning again, which can both be measured in the data. It also depends on the likelihood that candidates who lose the present election and, as a result, do not re-run in the next one, would have won the next election, had they decided to re-run. We refer to those candidates as "compliers."[27] This last term is not observable and our approach thus requires making an assumption about its value.

Assuming that this term is equal to 0, that is, that compliers would have had no chance of winning the following election, had they run, amounts to assuming that the effect on the unconditional likelihood of winning reported in Section 4.1 is entirely driven by the effect on winning conditional on running. Therefore, this assumption provides an upper bound on the effect on winning, conditional on running. Conversely, to obtain a reasonably conservative lower bound, we assume that, had they run, compliers who decided not to run in the next election as a result of losing the present one would have had the same probability of winning as the close winners who did run. This probability is equal to 58.3%.

We use the same method to derive bounds for the effect of a current victory on the vote share received in the first round of the following election, conditional on the candidate running again. The counterfactual is set again to zero when deriving the upper bound, and to the estimated outcome for close winners participating in the next election, namely 37.9%, when deriving the lower bound. We also estimate the effect of winning on the number of other candidates from the same orientation conditional on the incumbent being present. Unlike winning the next election, which is always equal to zero when the candidate does not run again, the number of competitors from the same orientation may take any value, whether the candidate runs again or not. Furthermore, winning the current election may affect ideologically close candidates' decision to run in the next election, even if the winning candidate does not run again themselves. We adapt the bounds formula to take this into account, as shown in Online Appendix E. Once again, we need to make assumptions on the expected number of competitors from the same orientation that would have run against a complier who did not run, if that candidate had decided to run. To compute the least conservative lower bound (i.e., the most negative bound), we assume that this quantity is equal to the number of candidates from the same orientation as any losing candidate who does not run again in the future: 2.3. To compute the more conservative upper bound, we assume that one competitor would have dropped out of the race if the complier had decided

27. Technical details and the exact formula we use to calculate bounds are provided in Online Appendix E.

TABLE 4. Bounds on the impact of winning on electoral success and candidate entry in the next election, conditional on running.

	Candidate wins, t+1 (1)	Candidate vote share, t+1 (2)	Orientation nb. other candidates, t+1 (3)
Upper bound	0.339***	0.199***	−0.116*
	(0.033)	(0.011)	(0.062)
Lower bound	0.080***	0.030***	−0.545***
	(0.023)	(0.004)	(0.068)
Bootstrap replications	10,000	10,000	10,000
Mean, left of threshold	0.381	0.310	1.292

Notes: Bootstrapped standard errors, shown in parentheses, are clustered at the district level and we indicate significance at 1%, 5%, and 10% with ***, **, and *, respectively. The unit of observation is the candidate. The outcome is a dummy equal to 1 if the candidate wins (column 1), the candidate's vote share in the first round in the next election (column 2), and the number of other candidates from the same orientation (column 3). The mean, left of the threshold gives the value of the outcome for the losing candidate at the threshold, conditional on the candidate running in the next election. Other notes as in Table 2, column (1).

to run again, so the number of candidates from the same orientation would have been 1.3.

To evaluate the significance of these bounds, we compute their empirical standard errors based on 10,000 bootstrap iterations obtained by sampling from our dataset with replacement. We complement the analysis by replicating the exercise at the party level: We measure bounds on the effects of a victory on the vote share of the candidate's party and on the number of other candidates from the same political orientation (that are not affiliated with the same party) in the next election, conditional on any candidate from the same party running again.

Table 4 displays the main results of this analysis at the individual candidate level. In column (1), we see that conditional on re-running, the victory of a candidate increases their likelihood of winning the next election by 8.0–33.9 percentage points, corresponding to 21%–89% of the mean value for close contenders on the left side of the cutoff. These upper and lower bounds are both statistically significant at the 1% level.[28] Moreover, consistent with the conditional effect on winning, column (2) indicates a sizable treatment impact on the subsequent first-round vote share conditional on re-running: 3.0–19.9 pp.[29] Again, both bounds are statistically significant at the 1% level. Winning an election also leads to a reduction in the number of other candidates from the same orientation: Conditional on the incumbent

28. We are confident that the positive value of our lower bound is not due to an unrealistically low assumption on the value of the unobserved probability of winning again among losing compliers, had they run again. Indeed, for the effect of winning conditional on running again to be equal to 0 or less, this unobserved probability would have to be larger than 76.3% (see Online Appendix E for details), which is much larger than our current assumption of 58.3%.

29. The effects on unconditional vote shares at the candidate and party level are shown in Online Appendix Figures A.1a and A.1b, respectively.

running again, the number of ideologically close competitors decreases by 0.116–0.545 (column 3). The conservative upper bound is significant at the 10% level and corresponds to a 9% decrease relative to the mean number of other candidates from the same orientation at the left of the threshold. This result indicates that incumbents who run again face fewer ideologically close opponents than challengers who run again.

Online Appendix Table A.4 corroborates these patterns at the party level. At this level of analysis, the ranges of possible values for the effects of a victory are narrower, due to lower effects on running: between 12.8 and 15.6 pp for the probability of winning again (column 1); and between 5.1 and 6.9 pp for the impact on the party's vote share in the first round of the next election, conditional on the party running again (column 2). Both the lower and upper bounds for the conditional effect on the number of candidates from the same orientation are negative, although the upper bound falls short of statistical significance (column 3).

Collectively, these results highlight the important contribution of the effect of winning, conditional on re-running, to the incumbency advantage in French parliamentary and local elections. Conditional on running again, the incumbent is more likely to win, obtains a higher vote share, and faces fewer candidates from their own orientation.

What fraction of the overall effect of winning can be explained by better coordination on the incumbent side, that is, by the reduced number of competitors from the same orientation? As we discuss at greater length in Online Appendix E, the answer depends on the probability of running again; the effect of winning on the number of other candidates from the same orientation in the next election, conditional on running again, which we just measured; and the effect of reducing the number of competitors from the same orientation on the probability of winning. We cannot credibly estimate the latter term as we do not have exogenous variation in the number of candidates from the same orientation who enter the race. Instead, we borrow an estimate from the existing literature: Pons and Tricaud (2018) show that the presence of a third candidate in the runoff of a two-round race reduces the probability that the ideologically closest candidate wins by 19.2 pp, using data from a similar set of elections. Using this estimate as proxy for the effect of facing one less opponent from the same orientation in the first round, we conclude that the effect of winning on the future number of competitors from the same orientation explains between 7% and 31% of the overall effect of winning on the probability of winning again

5. Mechanisms

Our main results show two major consequences of winning an election, which both contribute to the incumbency advantage in multi-party settings. First, an effect on candidates' entry in the next election: The winner (or another candidate from their party) is more likely to run again, while other candidates from the same orientation are more likely to stay out of the race. Second, an effect on vote shares and on the probability of winning the next election, conditional on running again. While the first effect is primarily due to candidate behavior and the second to voter behavior, they are likely to complement each other. Indeed, the incumbent may be more likely to run in the next election and their competitors (other candidates on the same side as well as the runner-up from the previous election) to stay out because they all expect voters to have a preference for the incumbent. Facing fewer competitors on their side, the incumbent candidate and party are better able to rally base voters and thus to win the election again.

Several mechanisms may drive these effects and favor incumbents' reelection. We focus on candidates' campaigning strategies and on the coordination between parties and between voters.

5.1. *Advantage in Running and Campaigning*

We first examine a "direct" mechanism that has only been partly investigated in the existing literature on incumbency advantage (see Section 1.1). Incumbents may be able to mobilize more resources and run better campaigns than challengers, possibly thanks to the experience and connections they gained in office. In turn, this may enable them to win more votes, conditional on running. Incumbents' decision to run again more often, while other candidates from the same orientation prefer dropping out, may come in part from other candidates anticipating that they will face these disadvantages.[30]

To test for the existence of an advantage in campaigning, conditional on running, we follow the strategy from Section 4.3 and derive bounds on the conditional impact of winning on the candidate's total campaign expenditures, total contributions, and manifesto personalization in the next election. Table 5 shows the results.

While the lower bounds on the impact of winning on total expenditures and contributions are positive (columns 1 and 2), they are small and non-significant. Therefore, we cannot conclude that incumbents are better able to raise money than opponents.[31] In contrast, both the upper and lower bounds on the impact on the originality of the candidate's manifesto issued before the next election are positive and significant at the 1% level. Winning the current election raises a candidate's future originality by 0.19–0.53 standard deviations, conditional on running again.[32]

30. In theory, candidates of other orientations could also be scared off if they expect the incumbent to have more resources. However, this effect is likely stronger for ideologically close candidates who are competing for the same base voters.

31. Finding a significant effect of winning the current election on campaign contributions in the next election could have been interpreted in two ways: increased campaign contributions to incumbents' campaigns may contribute to the effects we observe on winning or they may be driven by access-seeking donors' expectation that incumbents will win with a higher likelihood (Fouirnaies and Hall 2014). Instead, we do not find any evidence that donors give to incumbents more than to challengers in French elections. The difference with the United States could be due to stricter campaign finance regulations in France, which limit the influence of money in politics.

32. To calculate the upper bound on the effect on originality conditional on running again in the next election, we assume that, had they run again, the originality index of compliers who do not re-run after

TABLE 5. Bounds on the impact of winning on campaign money and manifesto personalization in the next election, conditional on running.

	Expenditure, $t+1$ (1)	Contribution, $t+1$ (2)	Originality, $t+1$ (3)	Personal pronouns, $t+1$ (4)	Past tense, $t+1$ (5)
Upper Bound	10579.803***	11676.458***	0.527***	0.304***	0.990***
	(1056.968)	(1214.701)	(0.105)	(0.061)	(0.126)
Lower Bound	459.623	719.414	0.190**	0.084*	0.364***
	(616.297)	(694.578)	(0.076)	(0.043)	(0.091)
Bootstrap replications	10,000	10,000	10,000	10,000	10,000
Mean, left of threshold	19046.601	20264.168	0.148	0.410	1.979

Notes: In columns (1) and (2), the sample is restricted to elections preceding an election for which data on campaign expenditures and contributions are available (i.e., elections held in 1985 or later). In columns (3–5), the sample is restricted to parliamentary elections preceding an election for which candidate manifestos are available (i.e., elections held between 1958 and 1993 as well as in 2012). The outcome is the candidate's campaign expenditures (column 1) and total contributions received (column 2) in euros, the originality of the candidate's manifesto as measured by its distance to any other manifesto from the same party (column 3), and the percentage of words in the candidate's manifesto that are personal pronouns (column 4), and past participles (column 5) in the next election. Other notes as in Table 4.

The originality of a candidate's manifesto relative to other candidates from the same party reflects their ability and effort to use messages that are personal and tailored to their local electorate. Hence, our findings suggest that incumbents tend to run higher quality campaigns than their competitors, possibly because being in office has given them access to better resources (e.g., better campaign advisors) or because they have formed better communication skills during their mandate. They may also advertise and take credit for their personal achievements in office, which challengers cannot do. Consistent with this interpretation, columns (4) and (5) of Table 5 show that incumbents tend to use first person's personal pronouns and past participles more often than challengers. The lower bound for the conditional effect of winning is significant for both outcomes (at the 10% and 1% level, respectively) and corresponds to about 20% of their mean value at the left of the threshold.

An alternative explanation is that challengers are less well-known, so their best chance to win votes is to advertise the party platform, which voters may recognize, rather than personalize their campaign communication. Either way, these results suggest that the incumbency advantage is, at least in part, due to the type of campaign run by candidates.

5.2. *Party-Level Dropout Agreements*

In two-round electoral systems, party agreements are common between the first round and the runoff. Parties with no candidate admitted at the runoff often endorse candidates belonging to other parties from the same orientation. Even parties with

losing the current election would have been equal to the first decile of the index among candidates who run again. This assumption is different than for other outcomes (e.g., vote share or campaign contributions), for which we assume that this counterfactual quantity is equal to 0. Indeed, unlike those outcomes whose minimal value is 0, the originality index can take any negative value.

TABLE 6. Impact of winning on the number of other party-affiliated versus independent candidates from the same orientation.

	Orientation nb. other candidates, $t+1$ (1)	Orientation nb. other party candidates, $t+1$ (2)	Orientation nb. other independent candidates, $t+1$ (3)
Treatment effect	−0.426***	−0.370***	−0.056
	(0.066)	(0.056)	(0.040)
Robust p-value	0.000	0.000	0.645
Observations	6,575	6,575	6,575
Polynomial order	1	1	1
Bandwidth	0.050	0.050	0.050
Mean, left of threshold	1.854	1.404	0.450
		Wald test (2)–(3)	
		Chi^2	Robust p-value
		17.59	0.000

Notes: The outcome is the total number of other candidates from the same orientation (column 1), the number of other candidates from the same orientation who are affiliated with a party (column 2), and the number of candidates from the same orientation who run as independents (column 3). Other notes as in Table 3, column (3). A Wald test of equality of coefficients from columns (2) and (3) is provided below. The test is performed by running two separate linear regressions of the outcomes in columns (2) and (3) on the treatment dummy, the running variable, and the interaction term. The Wald test is then performed on the estimates, stored with the *suest* Stata command.

a candidate qualified for the runoff may agree to ask their candidate to drop out and endorse another candidate from the same political orientation. Here, we examine situations in which parties agree on a common candidate even before the first round. Sister parties from the same orientation may coordinate and agree to leave the incumbent candidate or party unchallenged, in order to avoid splitting the votes between them and ideologically close opponents. In exchange, the incumbent party may agree to stay out of races in other constituencies or for other offices in the same locality. In the presence of such party coordination, one may expect the negative impact of winning on the number of other candidates from the same orientation in the next election to be stronger for candidates affiliated with a party than for independent candidates. Indeed, the latter are less likely to be affected by party-level agreements when they decide whether or not to run, since they are not affiliated with any party.

To test this hypothesis, we estimate equation (1) in the orientation-level sample, using as outcomes the number of other candidates from the same orientation that are affiliated with a party and the number of other candidates from the same orientation that run as independents, in the next election. Independent candidates are those whose political label assigned by the Ministry of the Interior does not correspond to a party organization. The results, shown in Table 6, reveal that the overall impact of winning on dropout decisions of ideologically close candidates is almost entirely driven by candidates affiliated with a party: Winning the current election reduces the number of party-endorsed competitors from the same orientation by 0.37, an estimate that is significant at the 1% level and represents a 26% decrease relative to the mean at the left of the threshold (column 2). Conversely, the effect on the number of independent competitors from the same orientation is non-significant and much smaller in magnitude (column 3). As reported in the bottom of Table 6, we can reject the null hypothesis that the two coefficients are equal.

These results provide suggestive evidence that party-level agreements play a key role in determining who enters the race. If the factor deterring candidates from the same orientation as the incumbent from entering the race was their expectation that voters will favor the incumbent (due, for instance, to their accumulated experience), thereby reducing their own chances of winning, the two coefficients shown in Table 6 should be of similar magnitude. Indeed, winning the current election should deter all competitors from entering the next race, whether they are endorsed by a party or not. Instead, the fact that the effect on the number of future competitors from the same orientation that are affiliated with a party is much larger suggests that party coordination is a first-order determinant of candidates' decision to run. One possible interpretation is that parties make national agreements to avoid presenting a candidate in constituencies in which the incumbent is affiliated with an allied party. Incumbency may thus be used by allied parties as a coordination device to limit the number of ideologically close competitors. Instead, independent candidates are not bound by such agreements. It is also possible that incumbent parties are in a better position to make promises or give political favors to their allies. For instance, the incumbent's party may promise not to field a candidate in the next local elections or to send funds to some specific localities.[33]

The analysis above considers agreements between parties from the same *orientation*, as these broadly defined orientations remain stable over time. As shown in Online Appendix Table A.5, we find very similar results when we estimate the impact of winning on the entry of other candidates from the same *coalition*, defined as alliances formed between left- or right-wing parties prior to the election.[34] We also find in Online Appendix Table A.6 that the impact of winning on the number of other candidates from the same orientation in the next election is larger for candidates who are presently facing a large number of ideologically close competitors: Winning the current election against an above-average number of competitors from the same orientation reduces the future number of such competitors by 0.528 (column 2) against 0.378 for candidates facing a below-average number of same-orientation competitors (column 4). The incumbency advantage is similar in size for both types of candidates (columns 1 and 3), suggesting that incumbents who won against many candidates from the same orientation manage to reach dropout agreements to secure their probability of winning the next election.

33. Similarly, Cox (1997) argues that parties that can negotiate at the national level and that have access to more resources are better able to solve coordination issues regarding how many candidates should run in single non transferable vote systems, such as Japan.

34. These coalitions are less stable over time (e.g., candidates from the Green party used to run alone but started joining the left-wing coalition in 1992). We hand-coded coalitions formed by the seven major parties in our sample, as described in Online Appendix D.3.

5.3. *Focal Point Effects*

We finally test whether the incumbency advantage stems from the fact that, in and of itself, and independently from the benefits of being in office, winning an election turns a candidate into a focal point. Being a focal point may attract voters and increase vote shares conditional on running: Voters may use the candidate (or the party) that won the previous election as a coordination device to avoid splitting their votes if they have to choose between multiple candidates from the same orientation.[35] Being a focal point may also facilitate dropout agreements among parties from the same orientation. However, it is not possible to directly isolate this focal point effect from other effects resulting from the incumbent being in office. Therefore, we provide an indirect test of this "focal point hypothesis" by estimating the effects of *another* focal point: the qualification of a specific candidate or party for the runoff. Qualifying for the runoff signals that a candidate is a strong contender and gives them visibility, but it does not come with any actual power (unless of course the candidate also wins the election).

5.3.1. RDD Framework. We estimate the causal impact of runoff qualification on future electoral outcomes (i.e., over the next electoral cycle) using a complementary RDD. Our running variable is the margin of qualification, defined in two different ways to account for the fact that two different types of candidates qualify for the second round, as indicated in Section 2.1: The two candidates who received the most votes in the first round, and any other candidate who passed the qualification threshold of votes.

First, in races where the candidate ranked second in the first round passes the qualification threshold, so that a third candidate could also qualify by passing the qualification threshold, we estimate the impact for the third-ranked candidate to qualify. We use one observation per race as in Pons and Tricaud (2018), and define the running variable as the difference between the first round vote share of this candidate and the qualification threshold.[36] For example, in elections with a qualification threshold equal to 12.5% of registered voters, third-ranked candidates with a first round vote share of 12.5% or more are treated and their running variable is positive. Conversely, third-ranked candidates with a vote share lower than 12.5% are not treated and their running variable takes a negative value.

35. In Duverger (1972)'s terminology, voters rallying prominent candidates who have better chances of winning is a "psychological effect." This effect may reflect both the higher visibility of runoff candidates and the bad publicity associated with failing to qualify for the runoff.

36. Unlike Pons and Tricaud (2018), we study the impact of the qualification of the third-ranked candidate in election t on this candidate's own electoral success in election $t+1$, not on the electoral success of the other candidates qualified in the runoff of election t. The qualification threshold was 5% of cast votes for parliamentary elections before 1967, 10% of registered voters for parliamentary elections from 1967 to 1973 and local elections before 2015, and 12.5% of registered voters for the remaining elections. All vote shares and qualification thresholds use the number of registered voters as denominator.

Second, in races where the second-ranked candidate does not pass the qualification threshold, the only candidates allowed to compete in the runoff are the top two candidates. In other words, the candidates qualified for the second round are the first candidate and whoever of the two next candidates gets the most votes. We estimate the impact for the second-ranked candidate to qualify by getting more votes than the third-ranked candidate.[37] Formally, we use two observations per race, corresponding to the second and third-ranked candidates, who are respectively treated and not treated. We define the running variable as the (positive) difference between the second and third candidate's vote shares, for the second candidate; and as the (negative) difference between the third and second candidate's vote shares, for the third candidate.

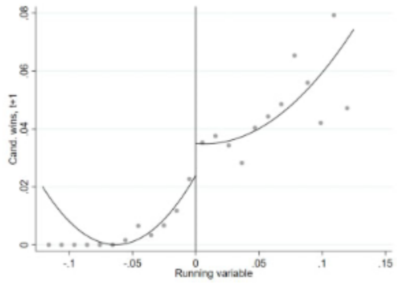
We pool both sets of races to estimate the overall impact of qualifying for the runoff. We use a specification in the form of equation (1), where the running variable MARG is defined as described above, and with a fixed bandwidth of 2.5 pp.[38] Online Appendix F provides additional details on the sample and on our identifying assumptions.

5.3.2. Results. As shown in Figure 4, the probability of winning the next election (Figure 4(a)), of running again (Figure 4(b)), and of qualifying for the runoff again in the next election (Figure 4(c)) all jump at the qualification threshold. Table 7 provides formal estimates. Despite the jump visible in Figure 4(a), the effect on winning the election is not statistically significant (column 1). However, qualifying for the runoff does raise a candidate's likelihood to run again and to qualify for the runoff in the next election, by 5.0 and 4.9 pp, which is significant at the 10% and 5% level, respectively (columns 2 and 3).

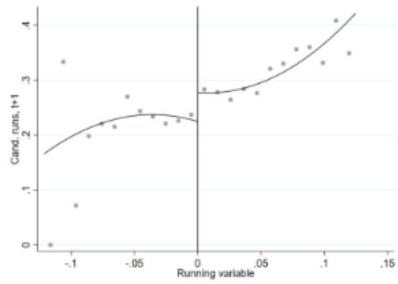
It is important to note that qualifying for the runoff increases the likelihood that a candidate wins the current election from 0% to 3.5%, as shown in column (1) of Online Appendix Table A.9. But we know from Section 4 that winning the current election increases the likelihood of competing in the next one and winning it. Therefore, the effects of qualifying for the runoff on outcomes at $t+1$ could be driven, in part, by the increased likelihood of winning at t. Multiplying the effect of runoff qualification on winning at t (shown in Online Appendix Table A.9, column 1) by the effects of winning at t on $t+1$ outcomes (shown in columns 2–4), we obtain predicted effects of 0.9, 1.1, and 0.9 pp on winning, running, and qualifying for the runoff of the

37. The effects obtained with this second source of variation (shown in isolation in Online Appendix Table A.7) may capture both the impact of qualifying for the runoff and the impact of obtaining a higher rank (second instead of third). As shown by Anagol and Fujiwara (2016) and Granzier, Pons, and Tricaud (2023a), obtaining a higher rank may affect future outcomes in and of itself, independently of the visibility that comes from qualifying for the runoff. Our results are qualitatively similar, albeit smaller in magnitude, when using only the first source of variation (Online Appendix Table A.8), indicating that qualification matters per se, independently of ranking effects.

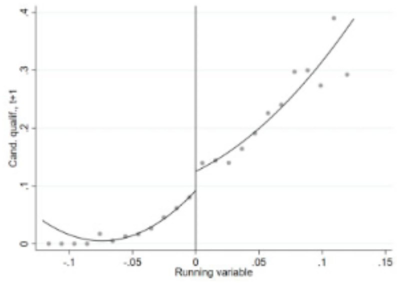
38. We use a bandwidth of 2.5 instead of 5 pp because the support of the running variable is much smaller than in our main RDD. In addition, while our running variable and bandwidth are defined as shares of cast votes when we estimate the impact of winning the election, they are defined as shares of registered voters when we estimate the impact of qualifying for the runoff.



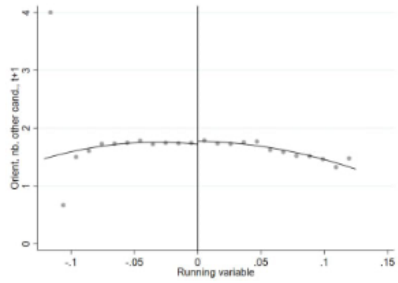
(a) Candidate wins the next election



(b) Candidate runs in the next election



(c) Candidate qualifies for the runoff in the next election



(d) Number of other candidates from the same orientation in the next election

FIGURE 4. Impact of runoff qualification on electoral success and candidate entry in the next election. The running variable (the difference between the vote share of the third-ranked candidate and the qualification threshold or the vote share difference between the second- and third-ranked candidates) is measured as pp relative to the number of registered voters, and each bin is 1-pp wide. The graph is truncated at 12.5 pp on the horizontal axis to accommodate for outliers. In Figure 4(d), we use our orientation-level runoff sample. Other notes as in Figures 2 and 3(c).

TABLE 7. Impact of runoff qualification on electoral success and candidate entry in the next election.

	Candidate wins, $t+1$ (1)	Candidate runs, $t+1$ (2)	Candidate qualification, $t+1$ (3)	Orient nb. other candidates, $t+1$ (4)	Orient nb. all candidates, $t+1$ (5)
Treatment effect	0.012	0.050*	0.049**	0.062	0.109
	(0.008)	(0.021)	(0.015)	(0.055)	(0.054)
Robust p-value	0.342	0.056	0.021	0.343	0.113
Observations	7,706	7,706	7,706	7,252	7,252
Polynomial order	1	1	1	1	1
Bandwidth	0.025	0.025	0.025	0.025	0.025
Mean, left of threshold	0.016	0.228	0.067	1.744	1.961

Notes: The unit of observation is the candidate. The outcome is a dummy equal to 1 if the candidate wins (column 1), runs (column 2), or qualifies for the runoff (column 3) in the next election, the number of other candidates from the same orientation in the next election (column 4), and the total number of candidates from the same orientation (column 5). The treatment variable is a dummy equal to 1 if the candidate qualifies for the runoff in the current election. We use local polynomial regressions: We fit separate polynomials of order 1 on each side of the threshold, using a fixed bandwidth of 2.5 pp. The mean, left of the threshold gives the value of the outcome for unqualified candidates at the threshold. In columns (4) and (5), we use our orientation-level runoff sample. Other notes as in Table 2.

next election, respectively.[39] Importantly, all these predicted effects are smaller than the actual effects shown in Table 7, columns (1–3). These results suggest that qualifying for the runoff leads candidates to enter the next race more often and increases their future electoral success, as measured by vote shares and runoff qualification, whether or not they win the current race.[40] Since runoff qualification is unlikely to provide candidates with better skills or experience, we interpret these findings as evidence of a focal point effect, independent from any future quality differentials between marginally qualified and unqualified candidates.

In Online Appendix Table A.11, we implement the strategy described in Section 4.3 to derive bounds on the impact of qualifying for the runoff, conditional on running again. Results show that the bounds on the impact on winning the next election are both positive but not significant at conventional levels (column 1). However, the upper and lower bounds on the effects on the candidate's vote share in the first round of the next election (column 2) and on the probability that they qualify for the runoff again (column 3) are all positive and significant at the 5% or 1% level. They account for a 1.8–5.1 pp and a 8.7–16.8 pp increases, respectively.

The effects of runoff qualification on future electoral success seem to be mostly driven by voter behavior. Indeed, Figure 4(d) as well as column (4) of Table 7 show a non-significant and *positive*—rather than negative—effect of runoff qualification on the number of other candidates from the same orientation in the next election. The estimated effect on the total number of candidates from the same orientation is even larger, although it is not significant either (Table 7, column 5). In addition, bounds on the effects of qualifying for the runoff–conditional on re-running–on the number of other candidates from the same orientation in the next election are of opposite signs and non-significant (Online Appendix Table A.11, column 4). Unlike winning, qualifying for the runoff is *not* sufficient to reach dropout agreements and deter ideologically close candidates from entering the next race—even when the qualified candidate runs again in the next election. These results indicate the existence of a focal point effect driven by voters' choices rather than other candidates' decision to run.

Furthermore, as shown in Online Appendix Table A.14, we do not find any clear evidence that qualifying for the runoff significantly affects candidates' ability to raise campaign money or the personalization of their platform, conditional on running again: Most lower bounds are positive but small and non-significant. Finally, we find that qualifying for the runoff only benefits candidates who will not face other higher ranked candidates from the same orientation and will thus not have to share their increased visibility with any other ideologically close candidate, further highlighting

39. This exercise assumes that the impact of winning among closely qualified candidates is similar as among close winners. Supporting this assumption, close qualifiers who win the election also tend to win with a relatively narrow margin of victory: 7.1 pp, on average.

40. Online Appendix Table A.10 shows qualitatively similar but smaller effects at the party level. We also find that these patterns are mostly driven by the qualification of second-ranked candidates as opposed to the qualification of third-ranked candidates, suggesting that candidates are more likely to become focal points when fewer of them qualified for the second round (Online Appendix Tables A.7 and A.8).

the importance of focal point effects (see Online Appendix F and Online Appendix Tables A.12 and A.13).

Since candidates who marginally qualify for the runoff generally do not win the current election and we do not find any significant impact on the number of competitors from the same orientation, campaign money, and manifesto originality, we conclude that the impact of runoff qualification on electoral success at the next election conditional on running cleanly isolates a focal point effect on the voter side: Voters tend to rally candidates who gained visibility in the previous election. This effect is likely to be present also for candidates who won the previous election and, thus, to contribute to the incumbency advantage, even though it is harder to isolate in that case.

6. Conclusion

Using an RDD in French local and parliamentary elections, this paper shows that candidates who marginally win a race are substantially more likely to compete again and win the next election than their closest challenger. The effects are large (32.9 and 25.1 pp) and also present at the party and orientation levels.

Two complementary mechanisms contribute to giving incumbents an electoral advantage. First, some voters rally incumbents when those seek reelection. We find suggestive evidence that the effect of past victories on voter choice in future elections is driven by incumbents using more personalized campaign communication and by the fact that they become focal points. Indeed, using a separate RDD, we also find a substantial effect on future first-round vote shares of marginally qualifying for the runoff, which cannot be explained by any advantage resulting from being in office. This focal point mechanism also echoes previous work documenting voter coordination based on candidate rankings in the previous election (e.g., Anagol and Fujiwara 2016; Granzier, Pons, and Tricaud 2023a).

Second, winning an election decreases the number of ideologically close competitors faced by the candidate in the next election, particularly competitors endorsed by a party. This result suggests that incumbents reach dropout agreements with sister parties from the same orientation more easily than their challengers. In other words, party coordination is more effective on the winning than the losing side. This mechanism, specific to multi-party settings, reinforces other, more direct mechanisms giving incumbents an advantage, which are also present in two-party systems. However, the overall magnitude of the incumbency advantage remains smaller in France than in the United States (25% against 45%, as found in Lee 2008), even though the two-party system of the United States limits coordination failures. This suggests that other sources of incumbency advantage are weaker in France than in the United States. In particular, France's more stringent campaign finance rules may prevent incumbents from accumulating disproportionately more contributions than their opponents.

Since we use an RDD, all our effects are estimated out of elections in which the winning and losing candidates have virtually identical vote shares and average characteristics ex ante. One may thus be concerned that incumbents' victory gives them such an outsized political rent. True, part of the incumbency advantage may arise from "enriching" characteristics of incumbency: The experience accumulated by incumbents may make them objectively more qualified than challengers who were initially similar. Moreover, the fact that incumbency facilitates coordination across party lines may be seen as a positive result in and of itself. More concerning is the possibility that part of the advantage enjoyed by incumbents in multi-party systems results from the fact that they represent a focal point for ideologically close voters. This advantage may lead them to exert less effort and it may sometimes be sufficient to prevent their replacement by candidates who would better represent voter preferences or have higher valence. The systematic coordination issues arising on the losing side, when more than two candidates are present, should be considered when weighing the merits and drawbacks of voting rules conducive to the emergence of multi-party systems, such as the two-round plurality rule used in French elections.[41] Meanwhile, non-incumbent parties desiring to reduce their disadvantage relative to the incumbent may attempt to address coordination issues on their own, for instance, by organizing orientation-level primaries or reaching more stringent dropout agreements.

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41. The two-round plurality rule in single-member districts, which characterizes French elections leads to the emergence of a multi-party system in a majoritarian setting. This combination makes coordination issues particularly consequential. Multi-party systems can also emerge under proportional representation but coordination issues are less important in that case because all parties obtain seats proportional to their votes and may ally in the parliament, after the election.

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Supplementary Material

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